Although self-reliance and self-sufficiency still remain a major theme in Indian national discourse, the country is much better integrated with the global economy now than at any time since Independence. India's ties with the Gulf, with South-East Asia, with Europe, with the United States and even with China now have a strong economic dimension. Economic growth has become a key national priority for India's government. Every prime minister over the last two decades has stated that India must maintain a growth rate of 8–10 per cent and foreign policy is expected to help India achieve this goal. When India's growth rate fell down to below 4 per cent between 2009 and 2013, it impacted India not just domestically but also affected its status and negotiating ability abroad.

While India seeks exceptions, especially in the economic arena, it has always supported the idea of creating global norms through multilateral institutions. Critics see a dichotomy in India's almost zealous insistence on absolute autonomy while simultaneously championing multilateral institutions. Indians, however, would argue that India fully supports multilateralism but seeks to keep in check the prospect of global institutions becoming instruments of renewed dominance by major powers. A global order that allows international organizations to simply echo the desires of Western powers would be too reminiscent of the colonial era. In some ways India and the US have a similar perspective: both want to be part of multilateral organizations but prefer bilateral or regional agreements. While both countries support and subscribe to numerous multilateral institutions neither would like their participation in these institutions to impinge on their autonomous decision-making abilities.

As a champion of cooperation between sovereign nations, India has sought membership of almost every major global and regional organization possible. It has sought to play an active role in all these groupings, seeking to advance not only its own interests but also to voice the collective interests of developing nations. India sees itself as an example for other